

FEEL THE FEAR AND DO IT ANYWAY

The phenomenal classic that has
changed the lives of millions

SUSAN JEFFERS

The Big “So What”



All of us experience fear. Some people are crippled by it while others thrive in spite of it. **This book helps you to understand what is fear, and equips you with techniques and tools to conquer your fear and live life fully.**

Introduction



Jeffers believes that **fear is not a psychological problem but an educational one.**



Many of us think of fear as an obstacle that prevents us from moving ahead. In reality, fear surfaces whenever we take a risk or try something new. The key is to **re-educate yourself** to accept fear as a natural and necessary part of growth.



Everyone feels fear, yet some people move ahead in spite of it while others are paralyzed by it. This shows that the issue is not with fear per se, but how we *handle* that fear. To **deal with fear**, don't try to avoid or remove it. Instead, develop the skills to act in spite of it.

In this summary, we've organized the key ideas into 2 parts: “Understanding Fear” and “Overcoming your Fears”. **Use this book as a guide to re-educate yourself. Then, each time you feel afraid, use one or more of the tools provided to move ahead.**

KEY QUOTES

“Whatever the fear, this book will give you the insight and tools to vastly improve your ability to handle any given situation.”

“If everybody feels fear when approaching something totally new in life, yet so many are out there ‘doing it’ despite the fear, then we must conclude that fear is not the problem.”

Understanding Fear



Where your fear comes from



There are 3 key levels of fear:

- Level 1 fears are “surface stories” that you tell yourself about what will happen (e.g. aging, being alone) or things you must do (e.g. making a career switch, making a speech). Often, the fear of 1 thing can spill over into other areas (e.g. a fear of meeting new people can induce fear of crowds, parties, public speaking etc.)
- Level 2 fears involve your inner states of mind rather than external factors. These are generalized fears that cut across many areas of life—such as the fear of rejection, failure, success—to reflect your sense of self and abilities.
- Beneath every fear is the ultimate fear that you won't be able to handle something, i.e. all fears are fundamentally due to a lack of confidence. Use the tools and ideas in this book to build the confidence that you can handle anything in your life. When you can shift your dominant thoughts from “I can't handle it” to “I will handle it”, you'll fear virtually nothing.



While it's useful to know how your past has caused your fears, the solution comes from taking action in the present.

- Most fears are instilled from childhood. For example, you may have grown up with protective parents who'd constantly worry and warn you to be careful. These send subtle signals that you can't handle yourself.
- However, there's no point examining the past. Instead, focus on the present and take action to change what you don't like. If you don't want your fears to stop you from getting the most out of life, make a decision now to conquer your fears.

KEY QUOTES

“One of the insidious qualities of fear is that it tends to permeate many areas of our lives.”

“At the bottom of every one of your fears is simply the fear that you can't handle whatever life may bring you.”

“If something is troubling you, simply start from where you are and take the action necessary to change it.”



The 5 Truths about Fear

A key idea in the book is this: when you can accept your fear and act in spite of it, you'll naturally overcome it. Jeffers helps us to understand why this is so, by breaking it down into 5 truths:



Truth #1: *So long as you're growing and trying something new, you will feel fear.* Hence, there's no point in trying to avoid your fears.



Truth #2: Many people are trapped by when-then excuses, i.e. "when this happens, then I'll do that". The only way to remove a fear is to do keep doing what you fear to do. When you face the unknown and handle it, you'll learn to do it better each time and gradually lose your fear of it.



Truth #3: *It's less scary to push through a fear than to constantly feel crippled and worried about the "what-ifs".* Each time you confront a fear, you remove some of the uncertainty. The more you do so, the more you realize that you can handle anything that life throws at you, and become more liberated and confident to live life fully.



Truth #4: *When you confront your fear and do it anyway, not only do you overcome the fear, you also feel good about yourself.* Mastering something you previously feared can be deeply satisfying and fulfilling.



Truth #5: *Everyone has their fears; they just don't usually talk about it.* In short, you're not alone.

Overcoming your Fears



Moving from Pain to Power

The key to handling fear is to learn to move from a position of pain (helplessness, depression, paralysis) to one of power (choice, energy, action), so your fear no longer holds you hostage.

KEY QUOTES

"We can't escape fear. We can only transform it into a companion that accompanies us in all our exciting adventures; it is not an anchor holding us transfixed in one spot."

"The real issue has nothing to do with the fear itself, but, rather, how we hold the fear."



“Power” refers to the inner strength and self-love that empowers you to take control of your life situations. Many women have been conditioned to believe that power is unfeminine and unattractive. In reality, love and power go together—people who are self-assured are generally better able to open up their hearts to love. If you’re a woman, Jeffers recommends that you reprogram your beliefs by repeating these affirmations at least 25x every morning, afternoon and night, feeling the energy of the words as you do so:

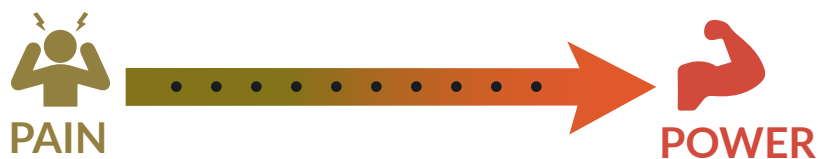
“I am powerful and I am loved.”

“I am powerful and I am loving.”

“I am powerful and I love it!”

➔ **Pain-to-Power Chart.** Pain and power falls on a continuum. Use this chart to develop awareness and start making empowering decisions.

- Place an enlarged version of this chart on your wall. You can also make different charts for various areas of your life, e.g. work, health, relationships etc.



- Place a pin on the chart where you currently see yourself. Move the pin daily according to how you feel that day.
- Use the chart to guide your daily decisions, reminding yourself of the direction you wish to go. If you make a bad decision that brings you pain, don’t get angry with yourself; learn from the mistake and move ahead so you shift back to power.
- Keep this exercise fun and light. You can even add fun quotes and/or make it a family activity by having your children make their own charts too.

Getting started is always the hardest. Hence, each step above—even a small one like pinning up the chart—can be powerful to get you moving and to build self-awareness.



Pain-to-Power Vocabulary. Words can empower or wreck us. Choose your words carefully to move yourself from pain to power.

KEY QUOTES

- Jeffers shares a simple experiment that demonstrates the power of words. Get Person A to hold out his arm at right-angle and repeat (10x) with emotion “I am a weak and unworthy person”. Then, get Person B (standing in front of Person A) to try to pull down Person A’s arm—this should be done relatively easily. Next, get Person A to repeat with feeling (10x) “I am a strong and worthy person” before getting Person B to try again. This time, Person B will probably find it much more difficult to pull the arm down!
- What you say reinforces your subconscious perception of yourself. Words like “I can’t” suggest that you’re weak or have no choice, while words like “I won’t” suggest that you have choices and know your priorities. Thus, it’s more empowering to say, “I’d love to come to the party, but I must prepare for an important meeting tomorrow” than to say, “I can’t come to the party.”
- In the book, Jeffers explains each of pain-power words/phrases below and why they empower or weaken you. Choose the words on the right column to speak more powerfully.

 PAIN	 POWER
I can't	I won't
I should	I could
It's not my fault	I'm totally responsible
It's a problem	It's an opportunity
I'm never satisfied	I want to learn and grow
Life's a struggle	Life's an adventure
I hope	I know
If only	Next time
What will I do?	I know I can handle it
It's terrible	It's a learning experience



Expand your comfort zone. All of us have a zone where things feel comfortable. Each time you do something “risky” outside that zone, it pushes your zone outward. By taking 1 small risk at a time (including changing your vocab), you’ll expand your comfort zone and the range of things that you can handle comfortably.

- Every night, before sleeping, plan the risks you’ll take the

KEY QUOTES

“The way that you use words has a tremendous impact on the quality of your life.”

“Begin eliminating the terribles, can’ts, problems, struggles, and so on from your vocabulary...The more powerfully you speak, the more you will be a force in the world around you.”

“As long as you are taking those risks—no matter how small—you are moving yourself to the right on the Pain-to-Power Chart.”

next day, and visualize yourself doing it as vividly as possible, as if you're practicing it in your mind.

- Each time you find yourself hesitating at something, try to push through the uncertainty. Even if you fail to overcome your fear at that moment, you can try again in the future.



Taking Responsibility



Being a victim. It's common for people to complain about how their kids make them worry, how their spouses make them upset, or how they're stuck in their jobs due to the bad economy.

- They blame their circumstances or other people for their lousy marriage, lousy career, unhappy life, and think that their lives would be better only if others change. In so doing, they're giving their power away and acting as if they are helpless victims.
- In reality, we are in control of how we react to any situation in our life. No one can force you to feel happy or sad—only you can control how you feel.



Taking responsibility means recognizing the choices and power that you have, and putting yourself in the position to exercise them. Jeffers breaks this down into 7 definitions of what it means to take responsibility, and how you can recognize yourself falling into a victim mindset:

- i. Don't blame an external party or factor for what you feel, do or have. Only you—and you alone—can control your thoughts, feelings and actions.
- ii. Don't blame yourself for “bad” decisions or for not being in control. You always do the best you can, based on your level of personal growth *at that point in time*. Don't bash yourself for what has already happened or think “I should've known better”. Embrace the experience, learn from it and move on.
- iii. Don't be a victim. Learn to recognize when you're not taking responsibility for what you are being, having, doing or feeling. Each time you feel emotions like anger, impatience, disappointment, self-pity or envy, step back and ask yourself,

KEY QUOTES

“Inside of you, just waiting to emerge, is an incredible source of energy, which is more than sufficient for you to create a joyful and satisfying life.”

“If you know you can create your own misery, it stands to reason that you can alone create your own joy.”

“Until you full understand that you, and no one else, create what goes on in your head, you will never be in control of your life.”

“When you blame an outside force for any of your experience of life, you are literally giving away all your power and thus creating pain, paralysis and depression.”

“What am I *not* doing in my life that’s causing me to feel this way about the person or situation?”

- iv. Silence the “Chatterbox”. We all have a little voice in our head that constantly plays out what-if scenarios and predicts how we can fail, lose, or get hurt. Most of us are so used to it that we don’t even realize it’s there. Become aware of this voice so you can silence it using the exercises in this book.
- v. Identify what’s trapping you. Most of us feel stuck because we constantly choose something we don’t want, in order to achieve something that we desire even more, e.g. to feel loved, get attention, or avoid rejection. By identifying these underlying desires, you can see new ways to get unstuck.
- vi. Decide what you truly want and take action. Only you will know what truly matters to you (e.g. health, relationships). Make things happen; don’t wait for others to give it to you.
- vii. Be aware that you always have choices. In any situation, you always have the power to choose how to feel and act, i.e. you’ll never have “no choice”. Choose the path that brings you growth and peace of mind.



Cultivate awareness. Learn to face your fears and develop inner power using these exercises:

- i. Think of an area where you feel stuck, and list down all the desires that may be keeping you trapped, e.g. what you don’t want to do or face, or the self-image you want to retain.
- ii. When you face a tough challenge, take time out to write down all the positive and negative ways you can feel and act. Imagine yourself going through all of them and realize the wide range of options you have. Consciously choose the positive responses.
- iii. Think of something you’re upset about, and list down all the ways you can change it to a positive experience. Look for new points of view in any situation.
- iv. Look for gifts or positive outcomes that came from a “bad” situation”, such as an illness or loss of a job.

KEY QUOTES

“There is no need to wait for anyone to give you anything in your life. You have the power to create what you need.”

“When you are aware of what you are doing...you will lead yourself instead of being led.”

- v. During conversations, pay attention to what you say, e.g. do you complain or focus on what you're learning?
- vi. Challenge yourself not to criticize or complain about anyone or anything, for 1 full week.



Practicing Positive Thinking

Our frame of mind affects how we feel and act, to create our reality and outcomes.



Unfortunately, we're surrounded by so much negativity and naysayers that it takes conscious effort to stay positive.

- When you're optimistic about something, it's common for others to tell you that you're being unrealistic. However, negative expectations are just as unrealistic as positive ones. In fact, it was found that more than 90% of our worries don't ever happen.
- To counter the negatives around you, practice positive thinking daily and surround yourself with positive people.



Use this program to cultivate positive thinking:

- Use affirmations (positive statements that something good is already happening) e.g. "I am relaxed, knowing I can handle anything." Place an audio player beside your bed, and play your affirmations first thing in the morning when you wake up. End your day with positive, relaxing materials and affirmations.
- Pick a special affirmation each day and write it somewhere you will see regularly. Repeat it at least 10x each time you see it.
- Whenever negative thoughts surface in the day, catch yourself and repeat the affirmations to outtalk the negative voice. Each time your positive energy wanes, take time out to recharge with your affirmations. Laugh whenever you can and lighten yourself up.
- Write positive quotes on index cards/ post-it notes and

KEY QUOTES

"There is an automatic assumption that negative is realistic and positive is unrealistic. Upon inspection, this is pure madness."

"Nothing is realistic or unrealistic—there is only what we think about any given situation. We create our reality."

place them everywhere. Take note of them as you go about your day.

- As you get dressed, play some relaxing or uplifting music and repeat your affirmations for at least 10 minutes.
- As you travel, plug in to positive audio/reading material instead of focusing on the traffic.



Making “No-Lose Decisions”

Most of us are conditioned to be afraid of making mistakes and bad decisions. We try to figure out if each option is right or wrong, then spend huge amounts of time revisiting our decisions.

In reality, you can't predict the future, and every path comes with opportunities. **Make “no-lose decisions” by considering only the opportunities and what can go right with each option.**



When making a major decision:

- Focus only on potential gains, not potential losses;
- Research your alternatives so you understand your options;
- Identify your priorities, giving yourself time to gradually discover what truly matters to you;
- After doing your research and considering your options, trust your intuition; and
- Relax in the knowledge that you'll be able to handle any “bad” decision and learn from it. Treat your whole life as a university, so you can view events like divorce, illness, or retrenchment merely opportunities to learn and grow.



After making a decision:

- Discard your expectations of how things “should” be. Focus fully on the actual opportunities in front of you, rather than dwell on the what-ifs.
- Accept full responsibility for the decision. Never blame others if things don't go well. Instead, feel good about the

KEY QUOTES

“There really is nothing to lose, only something to gain, whatever the choices you make or actions you take in life.”

“There was no right or wrong decisions, just different ones.”

“It is through confusion that you finally come to clarity.”

“Security is not having things; it's handling things.”

“An upset in your life is beneficial, as it tells you that you are off course in some way and you need to find your way back to your particular path of clarity once again.”

lessons you're learning and embrace your mistakes as a natural part of growth.

- Allow yourself to change course. If you've done your best to make something work, but it turns out to be a bad choice, let it go and move on. There's no point in protecting a past decision for the sake of doing so. Instead, focus on course-correction, recognizing that what's "right" for you could change as you grow. Listen to your inner cues—if you're feeling confused, it's a sign that you may be off-track.



Handling Relationship Changes

As you grow, your close friends and family members may feel uncomfortable and start reacting negatively.



Don't be afraid to change or expand your social circle.

- Both positivity and negativity are contagious. As you become more positive, you may find it less enjoyable to be around negative people (including friends who blame and complain). Don't be afraid to outgrow your old friends. Stay true to your path—those who're keen to grow will eventually shift under your influence, while others will gradually disappear.
- Expand your circle by consciously reaching out to people you admire. Find their contacts and initiate contact via a phone call or email. You can also meet positive, growth-oriented people at self-improvement workshops or seminars.
- Likewise, your spouse may feel threatened by your growth. Have faith that he/she wants the best for you, and will one day appreciate your positive changes. If you eventually end an unhealthy relationship, be confident that you'll find a positive mate who'll support you on your growth.



As you try to overcome your fears, you may feel frustrated if your friends/family seem unsupportive. **Initially, you may swing between aggression and passivity as you learn how to assert yourself.**

- If your loved ones discourage you from stepping out or tell you that you that you'll fail, don't lash out at them. Instead, understand their insecurity, share your confidence and let

KEY QUOTES

"If you've truly committed yourself to something, given it everything you've got, and then concluded that it is not for you—move on to something else."

"Most of us are not aware that we belong to the moan and groan crowd until we stop moaning and groaning."

"Like attracts like. As you begin to change, you will automatically draw and be drawn to a different kind of person."

"As soon as you stop agreeing with their victim act, they will either disappear or join you on the path to power and love."

them know you want their support, e.g. “I understand why you feel I’m being selfish. I’ve not been as available to you as before. It’s not easy for me to change, but I really want to grow myself. I’d love to have your support and I want you to know that I love you very much. How can we improve the situation together?”

- *Be patient.* Give yourself the time and space to learn and adjust. Try to center yourself using relaxation audios, meditation, or affirmations.

Living a Whole Life

It’s common for people to devote their entire lives to someone or something (e.g. their spouse, kids, or work), and feel devastated when they lose what they consider to be the centre of their lives.



Your life comprises many aspects, including love, friendships, personal growth, leisure, work, family, contribution etc.



Plot out the key areas of your life on a whole-life grid, and make a commitment to grow each of these areas. Try to include “contributions” as one of the key areas for fulfilment and growth.

- Having a full grid will make it less scary to lose any one component. Even if something happens (e.g. losing your job), you won’t feel as if your entire life has collapsed, and it’ll be easier to rebuild that part of your grid.

 Contribution	 Love	 Career
 Growth	 Higher Self	 Friendship
 Hobby	 Family	 Leisure

- Focus on each box in your grid, visualizing what you’d want that aspect of your life to be like. Imagine what you’d do and feel if you truly care about and are committed to that area, then take concrete actions to make your vision a reality. Stay motivated by plugging in to a self-help group, a growth buddy or a professional who can help you stay on-track.

KEY QUOTES

“When we are concerned with something bigger than ourselves, our fears are greatly diminished.”

“Whatever you create in your grid can become a reality—if you are committed to taking the necessary action.”

- Keep asking, “How whole is my life?” and set daily goals for *all* the boxes in your grid, rather than focus on only 1-2 areas.



Saying “Yes” to the Universe

One of the keys to facing your fears is to learn to accept what life puts in your path, even if it’s painful.



Saying “yes” doesn’t mean giving up. It’s about facing the realities of the situation so you’re in a position of power to act on it.

- Don’t resist what is. Imagine you’ve just lost both your legs after a major car accident. Rather than lament “why me?” and wish it didn’t happen, accept what has happened and focus on what you can do with the situation.
- Don’t deny your pain, as it’d only build up and manifest in other ways (e.g. anger, depression or physical ailments). Accept and deal with the pain, without blaming yourself.



To help yourself say “yes”:

- Read up about others who’ve found meaning in dire situations e.g. those who were imprisoned in concentration camps or were severely crippled. Realize that you can handle it too.
- Surround yourself with signs and quotes to remind yourself to make the most of your situation.
- Physically nod your head to affirm your acceptance of an idea, or gradually relax your body from head to toe to release tension.
- Practice saying “yes” to small day-to-day events, e.g. when you lose something or when someone spills coffee on you. Develop the habit of looking for positives in any experience.



Choose Love and Trust

When we give, most of us subconsciously expect something in return, be it appreciation, love or other rewards. **If you can give**

KEY QUOTES

“Let go and let the river carry you to new adventures by the way you experience your life. In this way—and only in this way—it is impossible to lose.”

“When we give from a place of love, rather than from a place of expectation, more usually comes back to us than we could have imagined.”

freely without expecting anything in return, you won't be afraid of being conned or losing out, and you tend to end up getting even more than expected.



There are many ways to start giving freely, including giving your appreciation, praise, money, love, useful information and resources, or your time and energy. The key is to offer them freely without expecting anything back in return.



Our fear of loss or sense of lack is all in the mind. Build awareness of your abundance by listing down at least 150 things that you had/have, and keep adding your daily blessings. Try giving away what you think you lack (e.g. money, time, energy), keep reading/listening to positive material and repeating your affirmations. When you realize how much you have, you will no longer be afraid to give.

KEY QUOTES

"What often looks like love is not—it is need."

"Lack is only in the mind."